

What Caused the Cold War?

Build an evidence-based answer to a contested question: what caused the Cold War, and who bears more responsibility for its onset?

? Historical challenge

By 1946 the wartime alliance between the United States and the Soviet Union had collapsed into mutual suspicion. Historians agree on the sequence of events but disagree sharply about the cause — and about who was more responsible. Weigh the evidence, note what conflicts and what is missing, and build a defensible working conclusion.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Kennan and Containment, 1947 – Office of the Historian, U.S. Dept. of State

SECONDARY SOURCE

Government history of Kennan's 'long telegram' and the birth of containment.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did Kennan explain Soviet behavior?
- How reliable is a single diplomat's analysis of a rival power?

SOURCES 2

Truman Doctrine – Harry S. Truman Library

PRIMARY SOURCE

Truman's March 1947 message requesting aid for Greece and Turkey.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How does Truman frame the choice facing the world?
- What might this speech leave out or exaggerate?

SOURCES 3

Telegram from Nikolai Novikov to the Soviet Leadership (Sept. 1946) – Wilson Center Digital Archive

PRIMARY SOURCE

The Soviet ambassador's warning that the U.S. sought global domination.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How does the Soviet view mirror the American one?
- Why is it important to read both sides' cables?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

Historical question

What caused the Cold War — and who bears more responsibility for its onset (roughly 1945–1950): the United States or the Soviet Union?

What we think we know

By 1945–46 the alliance had collapsed over the political future of Eastern Europe (especially Poland) and occupied Germany. Between 1947 and 1949 the US adopted containment (Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, NATO) while the USSR consolidated Eastern Europe and rejected the Marshall Plan. Both sides genuinely feared the other.

1 Evidence 1

SOURCE

Kennan's 'Long Telegram' (Feb. 1946)

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

Primary — U.S. diplomatic cable

EVIDENCE

A senior U.S. diplomat argues Soviet hostility comes from ideology plus historic Russian insecurity, and must be met with long-term 'containment.'

WHY IT MATTERS

2 Evidence 2

SOURCE

Truman Doctrine Address to Congress (March 12, 1947)

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

Primary — presidential speech

EVIDENCE

Truman frames world affairs as a choice between 'free' and 'totalitarian' ways of life and commits U.S. aid to nations resisting communism.

WHY IT MATTERS

3 Evidence 3

SOURCE

Novikov Telegram (Sept. 27, 1946)

PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?

Primary — Soviet diplomatic cable

EVIDENCE

The Soviet ambassador argues the United States is seeking global military and economic domination — the mirror image of Kennan's warning.

WHY IT MATTERS

Documents the Soviet side's fears, essential for weighing responsibility

It became the intellectual foundation of U.S. Cold War strategy — it shows how American policymakers interpreted Soviet behavior.

RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

One official's analysis, written to persuade Washington; it reads Soviet intentions from the outside, not from Soviet records.

Marks the public, global turn to containment and shows how the U.S. justified its commitments ideologically.

RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

Political rhetoric designed to win funding; scholars argue it may have overstated the threat and universalized a specific crisis.

fairly rather than one-sidedly.

RELIABILITY / LIMITATION

Also one diplomat's interpretation; historians debate how much it reflected Stalin's actual thinking, and it too reads the adversary from the outside.

Conflicting evidence

Historians divide into schools. Orthodox interpretations blame Soviet expansionism; revisionist interpretations emphasize U.S. economic interests and 'atomic diplomacy'; post-revisionists stress a mutual security dilemma with shared responsibility. The same events (Marshall Plan, Berlin) read as defensive or provocative depending on the lens.

Missing evidence

The biggest gap is direct evidence of Soviet internal decision-making — Stalin's private calculations and Politburo deliberations. Soviet records opened only partially after 1991, so interpretation long tilted toward the fuller U.S. archive.

Working conclusion

One defensible interpretation (not the only one): the Cold War arose less from a single aggressor than from a security dilemma — Soviet insistence on a controlled buffer zone collided with U.S. commitment to open, capitalist democracies, and each read the other's defensive moves as offensive. A student could reasonably weight responsibility toward either side using the same evidence.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your evidence cards with a partner. Did you rate the same sources as reliable?
- Did you and your partner lean toward the same 'school' of interpretation? What evidence moved you?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

This is a historiography exercise: students weigh competing interpretations (orthodox, revisionist, post-revisionist) rather than find one 'right' cause. Emphasize that reliability and point of view matter as much as content. Kennan and Novikov are mirror-image cables; the Truman Doctrine is public rhetoric. Do not quote document wording that students have not read — describe and cite.

Common misconceptions

- There is no single agreed 'cause' — responsibility is genuinely debated.
- A primary source is not automatically neutral or true; each cable argues a position.
- The Marshall Plan can be read as defensive aid OR as economic assertiveness, depending on lens.

Vocabulary

containment, Cold War, security dilemma, historiography, orthodox / revisionist / post-revisionist, Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, Iron Curtain.

Historical context

Yalta & Potsdam (1945); Kennan's Long Telegram & Churchill's 'Iron Curtain' speech (1946); Truman Doctrine & Marshall Plan (1947); Berlin Blockade & Airlift (1948–49); NATO (1949).

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Write a working conclusion answering the historical question. Cite at least two evidence cards, acknowledge conflicting interpretations, and note one limitation of your evidence.